Print Culture and the Modern World

The big idea

It is hard to imagine a world without printed material. Yet print is only a few centuries old. This chapter traces the development of print from **East Asia** to **Europe** and **India**, and shows how print changed the way people thought: it spread new ideas, created debates, and helped shape religion, reform, revolution and nationalism.

The first printed books

- **China**: the earliest kind of print technology was a system of **hand printing**. From **AD 594** onwards, books were printed by rubbing paper against the inked surface of **woodblocks**. Both sides of the thin, porous sheet could not be printed, so the traditional Chinese **'accordion book'** was folded and stitched at the side. China was the major producer of printed material for a long time, because its bureaucracy recruited through **civil service examinations**, which needed textbooks. By the seventeenth century, print diversified: merchants used it, reading became a leisure activity, and rich women began to read and even publish poetry and plays. Shanghai became the hub of new print culture with Western mechanical presses.
- **Japan**: Buddhist missionaries from China introduced hand-printing technology into Japan around **AD 768–770**. The oldest Japanese book, printed in **AD 868**, is the Buddhist **Diamond Sutra**, containing six sheets of text and woodcut illustrations. In late eighteenth-century Edo (later Tokyo), the illustrated work of **Kitagawa Utamaro** contributed to an art form called **ukiyo** ("pictures of the floating world"), depicting ordinary human experiences.

Print comes to Europe

- In **1295**, **Marco Polo** returned to Italy after many years in China and brought back the knowledge of woodblock printing. Soon Italians produced books with woodblocks, and the technology spread.
- Aristocratic circles and monastic libraries still preferred handwritten manuscripts on expensive **vellum** (a parchment made from animal skin). But hand-copying was expensive, laborious and time-consuming, and manuscripts were fragile, so demand for cheaper books grew.

GUTENBERG AND THE PRINTING PRESS

Johann Gutenberg, son of a merchant, grew up on a large agricultural estate and saw wine and olive presses. He learnt to polish stones, became a master goldsmith and made lead moulds for trinkets. Using this knowledge, he adapted existing technology to design his innovation: the olive press provided the model for the printing press, and moulds were used to cast metal types of letters. By **1448**, Gutenberg perfected the system. The first book he printed was the **Bible**: about **180 copies** were printed and it took **three years**. Between 1450 and 1550, printing presses were set up in most countries of Europe.

The print revolution and its impact

The **print revolution** was not just a new way of producing books; it transformed the lives of people, changing their relationship to information and knowledge.

A new reading public. Printing reduced the cost of books. Earlier, ordinary people lived in an **oral culture**: they heard sacred texts read out and listened to ballads. Now, a **reading public** emerged. Since literacy was low, publishers printed popular ballads and folk tales with pictures, read aloud at gatherings in villages and taverns. The hearing public and reading public became intermingled.

Religious debates and the fear of print. Not everyone welcomed print; many feared that uncontrolled printed words would spread rebellious and

irreligious thoughts.

- In **1517**, the religious reformer **Martin Luther** wrote **Ninety-Five Theses** criticising many practices and rituals of the Roman Catholic Church. A printed copy was posted on a church door in Wittenberg. His writings were reproduced in vast numbers; this led to a division within the Church and the **Protestant Reformation**. Luther said, "**Printing is the ultimate gift of God and the greatest one.**"
- **Menocchio**, a sixteenth-century miller in Italy, began reading books available in his locality and reinterpreted the Bible, formulating a view of God and Creation that enraged the Church. He was hauled up twice by the **Roman Catholic Inquisition** and executed. From **1558**, the Church maintained an **Index of Prohibited Books**.

The reading mania. By the end of the eighteenth century, literacy rates in parts of Europe were as high as 60 to 80 per cent. Pedlars called **chapmen** sold **chapbooks** (pocket-size books) in England; France had the **Bibliothèque Bleue**, cheap small books printed on poor-quality paper and bound in blue covers. Almanacs, romances, ballads and folk tales spread. Newspapers and journals combined information about current affairs with entertainment.

"Tremble, therefore, tyrants of the world!" By the mid-eighteenth century, people believed books could change the world. The French novelist **Louise-Sébastien Mercier** declared: "The printing press is the most powerful engine of progress and public opinion is the force that will sweep despotism away."

PRINT CULTURE AND THE FRENCH REVOLUTION: THREE ARGUMENTS

1. Print **popularised the ideas of Enlightenment thinkers** (Voltaire, Rousseau) who attacked tradition, superstition and despotism, and argued for the rule of reason.
2. Print created a **new culture of dialogue and debate**; all values, norms and institutions were re-evaluated.
3. By the 1780s, there was an outpouring of literature that **mocked the royalty** and criticised their morality, raising hostility against the

monarchy.

But note: print did not directly shape minds; people read selectively and interpreted ideas in their own way.

The nineteenth century. Mass literacy spread as primary education became compulsory in the late nineteenth century. **Children** became an important category of readers; a children's press devoted to literature for children alone was set up in France in 1857, and the **Grimm Brothers** in Germany compiled peasant folk tales. **Women** became important readers and writers; famous novelists included **Jane Austen, the Brontë sisters and George Eliot**. **Lending libraries** (from the seventeenth century) became instruments for educating white-collar workers, artisans and lower-middle-class people; some workers even wrote political tracts and autobiographies. **Technological changes**: by the mid-nineteenth century, **Richard M. Hoe** of New York perfected the power-driven cylindrical press, capable of printing **8,000 sheets per hour**. Publishers sold cheap paperback editions, serialised novels in magazines, and in the 1930s Depression, cheap paperbacks were released.

Print comes to India

Manuscripts before print. India had a rich tradition of handwritten manuscripts in Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian and vernaculars, copied on palm leaves or handmade paper. They were expensive and fragile, and could not be read easily as script was written in different styles.

EARLY PRINTING IN INDIA

- The printing press first came to **Goa** with **Portuguese missionaries** in the mid-sixteenth century. Jesuit priests learnt **Konkani** and printed several tracts; by 1674, about 50 books had been printed in Konkani and Kanara.
- **Catholic priests** printed the first **Tamil book in 1579 at Cochin**, and in **1713** the first **Malayalam** book.
- By 1710, **Dutch Protestant missionaries** had printed 32 Tamil texts.

- From **1780**, **James Augustus Hickey** began to edit the **Bengal Gazette**, a weekly magazine that described itself as "a commercial paper open to all, but influenced by none". He published gossip about Company officials; **Governor-General Warren Hastings** persecuted him.
- The first Indian newspaper was the weekly **Bengal Gazette**, brought out by **Gangadhar Bhattacharya**, who was close to Rammohun Roy.

Religious reform and public debate. Print fuelled intense debates over widow immolation, monotheism, Brahmanical priesthood and idolatry.

- **Raja Rammohun Roy** published the **Sambad Kaumudi** from **1821**; Hindu orthodoxy commissioned the **Samachar Chandrika** to oppose his opinions.
- From **1822**, two Persian newspapers, **Jam-i-Jahan Nama** and **Shamsul Akhbar**, were published. The same year, a Gujarati newspaper, the **Bombay Samachar**, was launched.
- The **Deoband Seminary**, founded in **1867**, published thousands of **fatwas** telling Muslim readers how to conduct themselves in everyday life and explaining the meaning of Islamic doctrines.
- The first printed edition of **Ramcharitmanas** of Tulsidas came out from Calcutta in **1810**. By the mid-nineteenth century, cheap lithographic editions flooded north Indian markets; the **Naval Kishore Press at Lucknow** and the **Shri Venkateshwar Press in Bombay** published numerous religious texts in vernaculars.

New forms of publication. The **novel** became popular; also lyrics, short stories, essays about social and political matters. **Raja Ravi Varma** produced images for mass circulation. By the 1870s, caricatures and cartoons appeared in journals, commenting on social and political themes.

Women and print. Liberal husbands and fathers began educating women at home. **Rashsundari Debi**, a young married girl in an orthodox household, learnt to read secretly in her kitchen and later wrote her autobiography **Amar Jiban**, published in **1876**, the **first full-length autobiography published in the Bengali language**. **Kailashbashini Debi** wrote about women's experiences; in

Maharashtra, **Tarabai Shinde** and **Pandita Ramabai** wrote with passionate anger about the miserable lives of upper-caste Hindu women, especially widows.

Print and the poor. Very cheap small books were sold at crossroads. Public libraries were set up from the early twentieth century. **Jyotiba Phule**, the Maratha pioneer of "low caste" protest movements, wrote about the injustices of the caste system in his **Gulamgiri (1871)**. In the twentieth century, **B.R. Ambedkar** in Maharashtra and **E.V. Ramaswamy Naicker (Periyar)** in Madras wrote powerfully on caste. **Kashibaba**, a Kanpur mill worker, wrote and published **Chhote Aur Bade Ka Sawal** in **1938** to show the links between caste and class exploitation.

Print and censorship

- Before 1798, the colonial state under the East India Company was not too concerned with censorship. By the **1820s**, the **Calcutta Supreme Court** passed regulations to control press freedom, and the Company encouraged newspapers that celebrated British rule.
- In **1835**, faced with urgent petitions by editors of English and vernacular newspapers, Governor-General **Bentinck** agreed to revise press laws. **Thomas Macaulay**, a liberal colonial official, formulated new rules that restored earlier freedoms.
- After the **Revolt of 1857**, attitudes changed; enraged Englishmen demanded a clampdown on the "native" press.
- In **1878**, the **Vernacular Press Act** was passed, **modelled on the Irish Press Laws**. It gave the government extensive rights to **censor reports and editorials** in the vernacular press. The government kept regular track; if a report was judged seditious, the newspaper was warned, and if the warning was ignored, the press could be seized and the printing machinery confiscated.
- Nationalist newspapers grew in number across India. When Punjab revolutionaries were deported in **1907**, **Bal Gangadhar Tilak** wrote with great sympathy about them in his **Kesari**; this led to his imprisonment in **1908**, which provoked widespread protests.

TWO "BENGAL GAZETTES"

Hickey's Bengal Gazette (1780) was English-run. The first Indian newspaper, also called Bengal Gazette, was brought out by **Gangadhar Bhattacharya**. Don't credit Hickey with being the first Indian newspaper editor.

BOARD FAVOURITES

"How did Gutenberg develop the printing press?", "Why did some people fear the effect of print?", "Role of print in the French Revolution" (5 marks), "Effects of print on women / poor people in India", "What was the Vernacular Press Act?" (3 marks), "Martin Luther and print".

Quick recap

- China: woodblock printing from AD 594; Japan: Diamond Sutra AD 868.
- Marco Polo brought woodblock printing to Italy (1295); Gutenberg perfected his press by 1448; Bible, 180 copies.
- Luther's Ninety-Five Theses (1517); Index of Prohibited Books (1558); Menocchio executed.
- Print helped spread Enlightenment ideas before the French Revolution.
- India: Portuguese in Goa; Tamil book 1579; Hickey's Bengal Gazette 1780; Sambad Kaumudi 1821; Amar Jiban 1876; Gulamgiri 1871.
- Vernacular Press Act 1878; Tilak jailed 1908.

Practice questions

1. The oldest Japanese printed book (AD 868) is the
   (a) Ramcharitmanas (b) Bible (c) Diamond Sutra (d) Ninety-Five Theses
2. Who brought the knowledge of woodblock printing to Italy in 1295?
   (a) Marco Polo (b) Johann Gutenberg (c) Martin Luther (d) Christopher Columbus
3. Martin Luther described printing as
   (a) the most powerful engine of progress (b) a danger to religion (c) an invention of the devil (d) the ultimate gift of God and the greatest one
4. The Vernacular Press Act of 1878 was modelled on the
   (a) French Civil Code (b) Rowlatt Act (c) Irish Press Laws (d) American Constitution
5. Rashsundari Debi's 'Amar Jiban' is important because it was
   (a) the first Hindi novel (b) a nationalist newspaper (c) a collection of fatwas (d) the first full-length autobiography published in Bengali
6. Gulamgiri (1871), which wrote about injustices of the caste system, was written by
   (a) B.R. Ambedkar (b) Jyotiba Phule (c) Periyar (d) Kashibaba
7. Which newspaper was published by Raja Rammohun Roy from 1821?
   (a) Samachar Chandrika (b) Bombay Samachar (c) Sambad Kaumudi (d) Kesari
8. Why did some people in sixteenth-century Europe fear the effects of easily available printed books?
9. "Print culture created the conditions within which the French Revolution occurred." Explain.

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. c 5. d 6. b 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes